

Sometimes, they've developed unrealistic expectations. In some cases, others have bailed them out for so long, they've never had to learn the true cost of living. They've never suffered the consequences of bad money management. They've never felt that bone-chilling fear of pending financial doom, the kind of fear that forces you to change. They've also never experienced the glory of turning things around and making them right again.

Here's the point: No matter what your 90-Day Number tells you about your current financial circumstances, you've had a good look at your internal financial wiring. And no matter what you learned, you now know there's room for improvement. It's entirely up to you to change. And you can.

Money Mistake: You're Drowning in Credit Card Debt

THE FIX: READ THE FINE PRINT

Spending too much is a disease. And credit card debt is a cancer. The first time you get a credit card bill and don't pay off the full balance, it's as if you've allowed the first financial cancer cell into your life. The compounding nature of those frightening interest rates is a monstrous thing to behold. Take a look at your credit card bill. Put on some reading glasses and peer at the dangerous fine print. By law, credit card companies are required to tell you how many years it will take to pay off your balance if you pay only the minimum each month. For instance, if you owe \$5,000 and you make only a minimum payment of \$100 a month at an interest rate of 19 percent, it will take you eight years and three months to pay that off. Now, get this: The average U.S. household is \$34,000 in debt. And that's just consumer debt! That's not counting mortgages. The numbers are staggering but true: The average American family owes \$27,000 in college loans and \$7,000 in credit card debt. Most of these debtors are buying cars on credit, or paying for vacations or expensive home renovations.

The credit card companies will tell you their ridiculously high interest rates are necessary insurance against people who defraud them